the Great or Xerxes had done for that of the Avesta and St Paul did for that of Christ. He indeed raised Buddhism from the position of a local faith to the status of a world religion.'[51]

Fifteen years after Barua, Romila Thapar's assessment of Ashoka, based on her PhD thesis, was published as *Asoka and the Decline of the Mauryas*.[52] This study, which has since enjoyed wide popularity, was both similar to and different from the many books that preceded it. Though the sections dealing with Ashoka's early life, accession, chronology, internal administration, and socioeconomic activity were written broadly in the spirit of her Indian predecessors, what gave her work a different flavour was that it sought to more carefully contextualize Ashoka in his time. So, for instance, his involvement in Buddhism was seen in the background of the 'unusually lively interest' that his father and grandfather displayed in eclectic ideas, those that came with the Greeks who travelled to their courts, as also via the religions anchored around the Ganga—Jainism and the Ajivika teachings.[53] Similarly, while dhamma was recognized as having been nurtured by Ashoka, it was simultaneously highlighted as being the king's novel solution to what he recognized as the problems of binding a multicultural society: 'To any intelligent statesman of the period it must have been evident that some kind of binding factor was necessary in order to keep the empire intact . . . The policy of *Dhamma* with its emphasis on social responsibility was intended to provide this binding factor.'[54] Equally, her work showed his policy of dhamma as evolving over his long reign which, towards the end, was seen as being marred by an overconfidence in his own achievement.[55] Examined closely, the book shows Ashoka as anchored in the circumstances and responding to the challenges of his time, but the persona that emerges from this conceptualization is all the same exceptional. A king who 'stressed the conscious application of humanitarianism in social behaviour, thus appealing not to the narrower religious instincts, but to a far wider and immediate feeling of social